

The valley outside the walls of Ranthambore Fort

SHUTTERSTOCK

MORE THAN JUST TIGERS

Tiger sightings aren't Ranthambore's only reward. The national park now offers many more perks

By **AMIT DIXIT**

It's not often that a national park boasts a Unesco World Heritage fort within its precincts, but Ranthambore has that honour. It is believed that the Ranthambore Fort was constructed over a thousand years ago by the Chahamanas for their capital. They called it 'Ranastambhapura'. Today, hundreds of visitors pass the fort daily on their safari jeeps, eager for a sighting of the elusive tiger. If they're lucky, they might even see one on the ramparts of the fort.

The town of Sawai Madhopur is the gateway to Ranthambore, the most popular national park in Rajasthan. Spanning an area of 1,334 square km and bounded by the Banas and Chambal rivers on the north and south, respectively, Ranthambore is noted for its large population of tigers. Machli, one of the most famous tigers in the world, lived in Ranthambore National Park until she died in 2016.

Tigers are typically not easy to sight, being solitary creatures who command large territories. But Ranthambore has an advantage. Being home to dry, deciduous forests and open grassy meadows, tigers are easier to spot here. Several watering holes across the park attract a wide variety of fauna, and patient visitors are usually rewarded with sightings. Padam Talao is the largest of the lakes in the park. One of India's largest banyan trees is close to the lake.

However, there's much more to Ranthambore than a tiger sighting. The park is home to leopards, elephants, antelopes, deer, wolves, wild boars, Indian bison, crocodiles and a variety of other fauna. As one of India's premier wildlife destinations with a healthy reputation for tiger sightings, Ranthambore is home to resorts of every stripe, not to mention high-end artisanal boutiques purveying everything from designer garments to jewellery, carpets and local crafts. Some of India's most luxurious tented accommodation sits at the park's edge. With gourmet meals and spas at hand, even if you don't see a tiger, you'll leave growling with satisfaction. ■

